

AUDIO PERFORMANCE

The Sony WH-1000XM6 come with a specially designed 30mm driver unit and supports various codecs like SBC, AAC, LDAC, and LC3 (LE audio ready). We tested in the LDAC codec and with DSEE Extreme (upscaling feature for low-res files) enabled, and equaliser set to none. I kept the volume around 60% on the OnePlus 13. I found the XM6 noticeably louder and has better bass output than the AirPods Max.

Based on the (V-shape) frequency response graph, the Sony XM6 has a warm, bass-focused sound with slightly relaxed mids and a smooth treble. That means the music would feel full and pleasant, but perhaps not very sharp or clinical like studio-grade headphones.

In my song-by-song analysis, I found the bass is full, rounded and satisfying on tracks like Bad Guy. Vocals are finely clear, so emotional recordings like Hurt feel close and intimate. The treble is smooth and controlled, which keeps harshness in check on brighter tracks like Centuries, but this also reduces sparkle in guitars and cymbals. Audio enthusiasts may not like how it handles complex portions of Pull Me Under by Dream Theater or Selkies by Between the Buried and Me.

In dense metal tracks such as Selkies, I felt the headphones didn't separate every layer clearly. I liked the spaciousness and staging in tracks like Hotel California by The Eagles or Hunter by Björk.

Overall, the Sony XM6 is tuned for comfort and long-term listening. It delivers a warm, enjoyable sound that works well for most genres, especially bass-heavy or modern pop music. It is not a detail-focused or analytical headphone, but a smooth all-rounder designed to avoid fatigue, even during hours of playback.

Now, in the Sony Sound Connect, you can choose different listening modes like Background Music (for distant ambience, as if you are listening to music in a cafe) or Cinema (for a spatial 360 feel). The Standard mode focuses

on direct sound reproduction, so vocals and instruments feel closer and more centred. It's better for clarity and detail. In Cinema mode, Sony applies virtual surround processing to widen the soundstage. It adds a sense of space and distance, which works well for tracks like 'Hotel California' that have layered guitars and ambient elements. But in the case of Under Pressure by Queen ft David Bowie, I prefer the intimacy and definition offered by the standard mode.



Spatial Sound with Head Tracking works only with supported phones like the Pixel. I tried it with 'Lose Yourself to Dance' by Daft Punk on a Pixel 10, but the difference compared to regular stereo wasn't clear to my ears. Similarly, 360 Reality Audio also needs supported apps and compatible tracks, and some of these apps require a paid subscription before you can use them.

ANC, CALL AND CONNECTIVITY

Sony positions the WH-1000XM6 as its best noise-cancelling headphones. For this, the company credits the new QN3 chip, which is said to be seven times faster than the XM5's processor, along with more microphones and an updated Adaptive NC Optimiser algorithm.

With ANC off, both the XM6 and AirPods Max let a small amount of ambient sound through. With ANC on, the XM6 creates a near-silent space. If you look for it, human voices are still faintly audible, but overall noise reduction is better than the AirPods Max.

SHOULD YOU BUY THE SONY WH-1000XM6?

The Sony WH-1000XM6 combines premium build, refined tuning, and best-in-class noise cancellation. Its foldable design makes it more portable than the XM5, and the lighter build adds comfort for long sessions. Sound is warm and full, battery life is excellent, and call quality is among the best in any wireless headphone today. Features like multi-device pairing, LDAC support, 360 Reality Audio, and a refined app experience round out a solid flagship package.

It's not without limitations. There's still no water resistance, which limits outdoor or gym use. The Speak-to-Chat, Adaptive Sound Control, and Spatial Sound don't work as reliably as advertised. While the sound is rich and easy on the ears, it's tuned more for everyday listening than studio-grade precision.

If you prefer a cleaner, more balanced sound, you can consider the Sennheiser Momentum 4 Wireless or the Sonos Ace. These may be relatively older models, but they are available at a lower price. And in case you are in the Apple ecosystem, you may consider AirPods Max, which also offers a warm sound signature, better Transparency Mode and seamless integration with other Apple products. But they cost more and are inferior in portability.

It costs more than the XM5 did at launch, but the upgrades feel justified.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 30mm | Impedance: 16-480 | RF: 4Hz-40KHz | Frequency Range: 2.4 GHz band | ANC: Yes, real-time adaptive | Mics: 12 Mic array | Tuning: Studio-level accuracy | Dimensions: (H) 173.85mm x (W) 78mm x (D) 189.25mm | Weight: 255g | Battery: 30-50 hours | Charging: Type-C wired / 2.75 hrs for full charge | Connectivity: Bluetooth 5.3, up to 10m

CONTACT

Company: Sony India | Phone: 080 6500 6500 | Email: Web Form | Website: <https://web.sony-asia.com/in/contact-us/>

Read more on Digit.in:
tinyurl.com/h08wb9